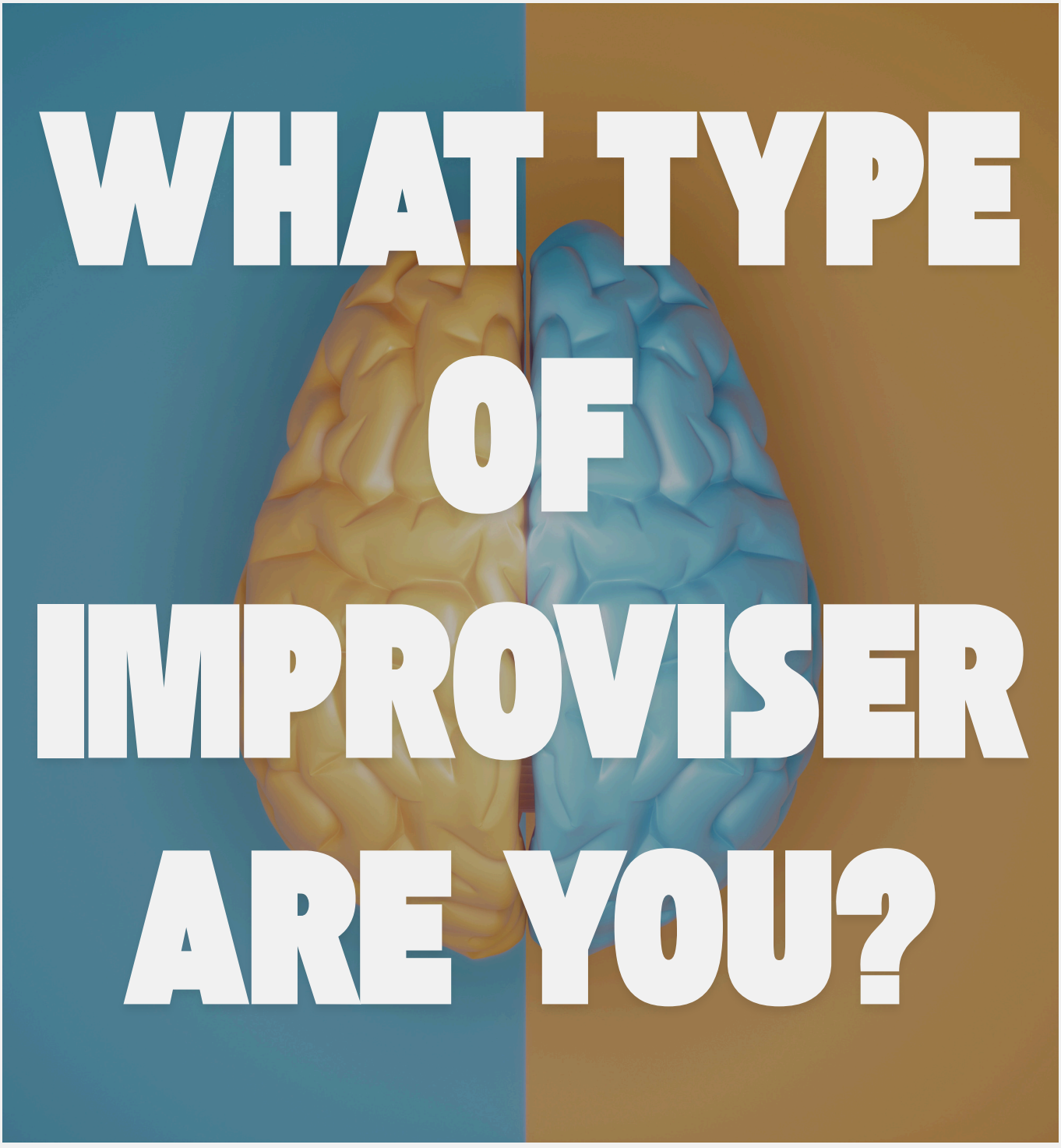
JAZZ LAB



WWW.JAZZLABMUSIC.ORG

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INTRO

Every musician has a different musical personality. And therefore, every improviser (regardless of classical or jazz background) has a different personality. This by itself is the proof that there is no one-fits-all music education method that serves all musicians.

Identifying your own musical personality can help you understand what are your strongest skills and what areas may need some support and hard work.

We should all strive to be as well rounded as possible. I love looking at John Coltrane as a model of the most well-rounded musician ever. He is the perfect mix of risk, control, intensity, gentleness, creativity, support, dexterity, heart.



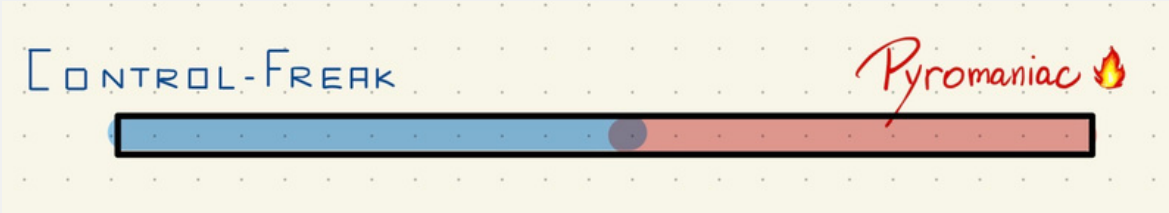
A good starting point is trying to identify whether your musical personality is Pyromaniac or Control-Freak. Obviously these are our fun , exaggerated and comic to stimulate self-reflection.

Pyromaniacs play mostly from the heart, they love to close their eyes, take risks, try difficult fast phrases beyond their technical ability, play complex sounds they may not even understand theoretically. PROS: creative, spontaneous, full of energy, excitement. CONS: often loose the form, make tons of mistakes, impatience.

Control-Freaks like organization, they like to play over the grid (rhythmic accuracy), respect the form, keep solos under control, addressing the chords properly. They like to understand what they are playing, and have a more pedagogical approach to improvisation. PROS: excellent analytical skills, good team player, can practice with more focus, overtime can grow and improve a lot. CONS: lack of spontaneity and risk taking.

Of course this is a spectrum, so each musician will fall on some point of this scale. Ideally we would all want to be right in the middle.

Once I identify where a student fits in this spectrum, I offer a set of exercises to help encourage the other side. Pyromaniacs need to learn structure, form, rhythmic rigor and discipline. Control-Freaks need to learn how to take risks, be spontaneous and less rational.

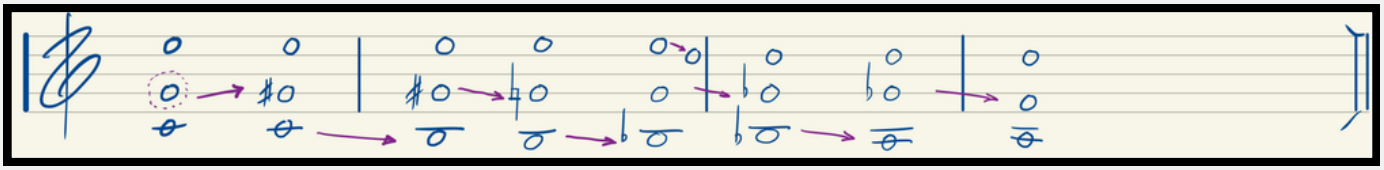


Here are a few exercises I suggest:

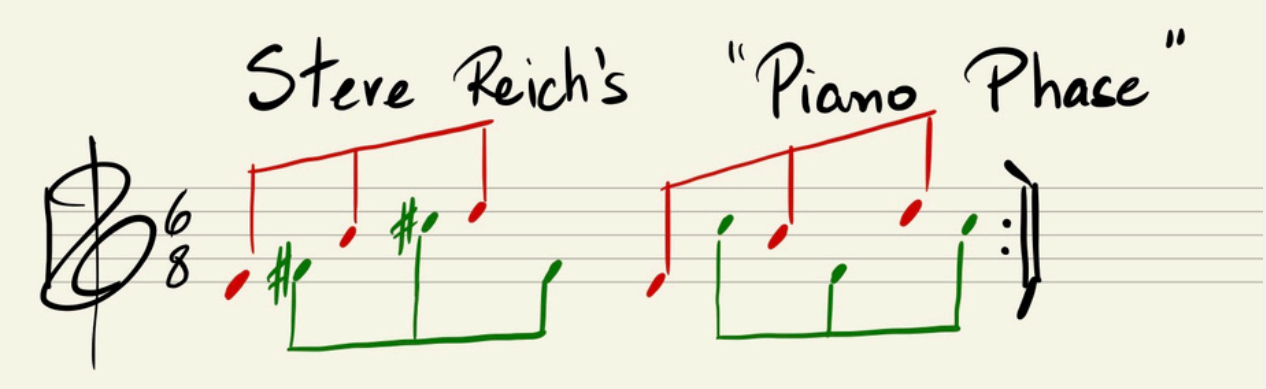
For the **Control-Freaks**

Start every day by playing completely free improv (whatever that means for you).
Practice with your eyes closed or in complete darkness.
Use some creative-constraints to dribble your analytical mind; for example:

Pick an open chord and establish an arpeggio; every bar, change one of the voices in half-step (up or down), and keep changing one voice at a time. Slowly your initial chord will start to morph into new harmonies, many of which are surprising and not easy to analyze. On guitar using open strings is another great way to dribble the immediacy of an over-analytical mind (creating chords that include many open strings, and shifting notes by half-steps).



The same can be done with more complex ostinati. I love piano ostinati that involve hand crossing (such as Steve Reich's Piano Phase). The hand-crossing makes it really hard for the brain to catch up on what's happening, and you can connect to a more intuitive playing. I recommend repeating these and shifting one note at a time in half-set up or down. Randomness is key here; a certain degree of randomness is important to free up one's imagination.

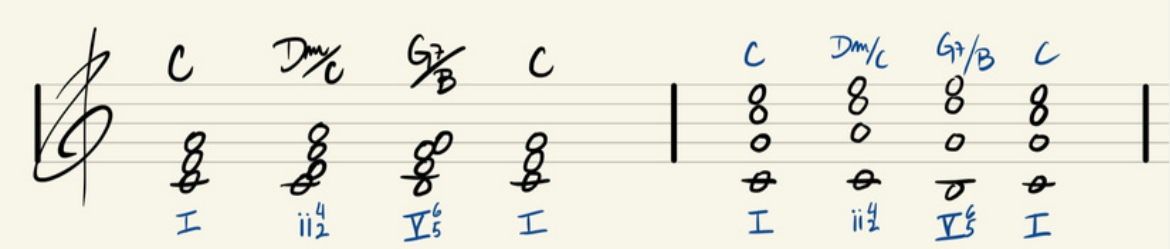


For the Pyromaniacs:

- Practice with metronome, with recordings, tapping the pulse with your feet.
- Try to hear the phrase you want in your head before playing it.
- Studies on form and structure:

- Motivic improvisation (improvising with the same fragment or motif), or the same exact rhythmic figure.
- Memorizing long forms: for example, analyzing Bach preludes, or specific standards, transposing the harmonies to many different keys and improvising using exactly those progressions.

• Learning as many long-forms as possible: standards, chromatic lament bass, La Folia, 12-bar blues, theme and variations.



For example, this is Bach's typical harmonic opening statement in the majority of his preludes. Try transposing this to other keys as accurately as possible, trying to improvise short melodies over it.
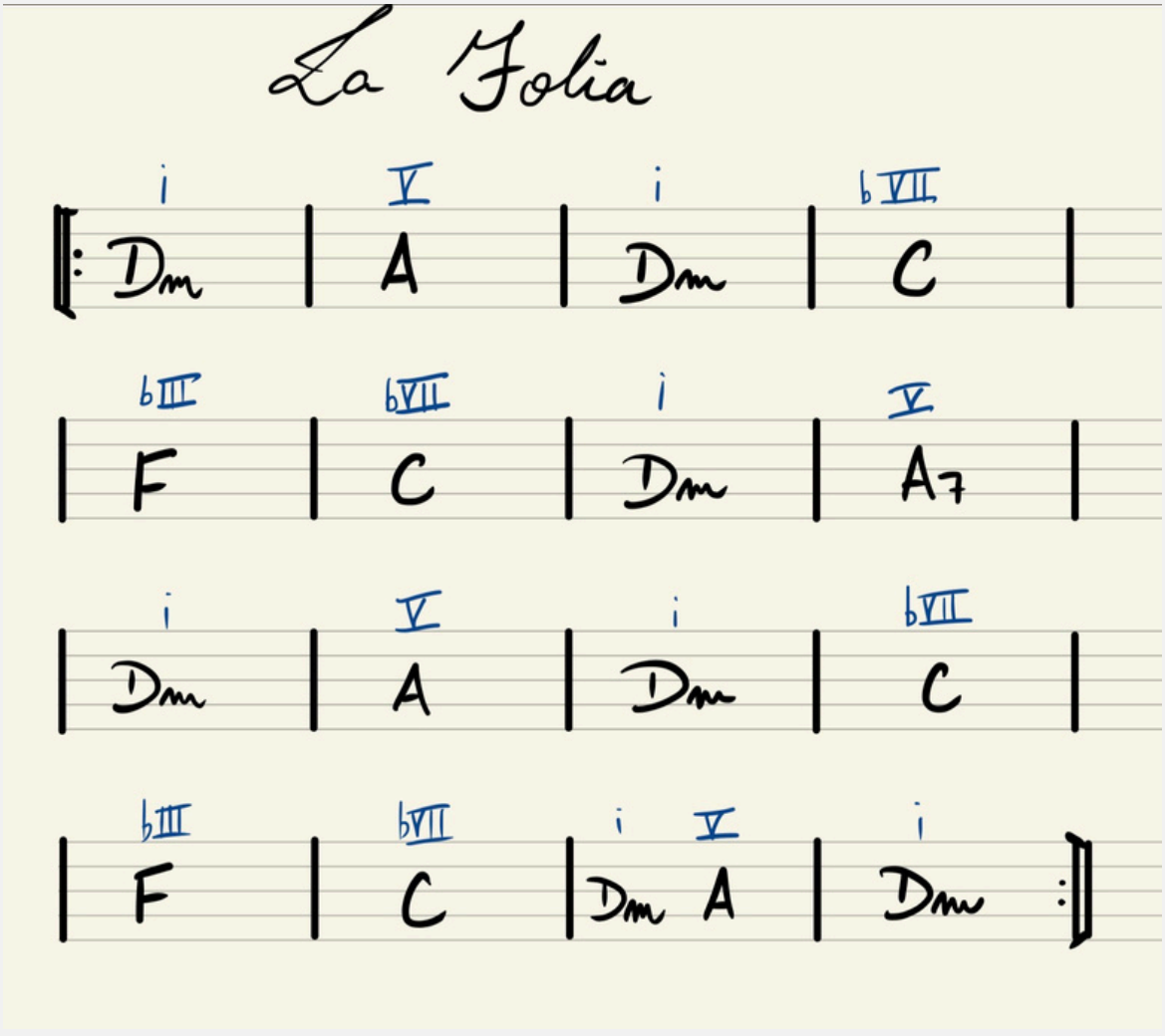
Below you can find a template for the La Folia, a famous harmonic form used during the Baroque period, just like a 12-bar blues form of the 17th century. Composers such as Marin Marais, Corelli, Vivaldi wrote many variations over these chords. A great exercise is to memorize this progression and try playing your own variations and improvisations with the recordings of Vivaldi's os Corelli's Folias.

